



BATTLE PANORAMA

This image, from a dioramic representation of the events, shows the torpedo squadron from USS Yorktown attacking the Japanese carriers Soryu and Akagi on the morning of June 4. Having to hold a steady course low over the sea to deliver their torpedoes, the bombers ran the gauntlet both of anti-aircraft fire from warships and predatory fighters.

“A number of black objects suddenly floated eerily from their wings. Bombs! Down they came straight toward me.”

JAPANESE COMMANDER MITSUO FUCHIDA
ON THE ATTACK OF THE *AKAGI* BY US DIVE-BOMBERS

of the Japanese combat air patrol. Although they made a brave job of occupying the Japanese fighters, they could not prevent the torpedo-bombers being decimated again. But concentrating on the low-flying aircraft, the

Zeros missed the American dive-bombers – Douglas Dauntlesses not only from the *Yorktown*, but also from the *Enterprise* – that fortuitously arrived high above the enemy ships at that critical moment. As the dive-bombers turned into their steep attack, Jimmy Thach remembered: “I saw this

glint in the sun, and it just looked like a beautiful silver waterfall, these dive-bombers coming down... I’d never seen such superb dive-bombing. It looked to me like almost every bomb hit...” In about five minutes three Japanese carriers – the *Akagi*, *Kaga*, and *Soryu* – were reduced to burning hulks, blackening the sky with columns of black smoke.

Despite the shock that the Japanese had received, they still had one carrier intact, the *Hiryu*. It flew off a wave of dive-bombers followed by a wave of torpedo-bombers, to deliver a counterstrike against the *Yorktown*. Since there were only half a dozen Zeros to provide cover for each wave of bombers, they were savaged by the fighters of *Yorktown*’s combat air patrol, as well as by the ship’s anti-aircraft fire.



DAUNTLESS DESTROYERS

Artist R.G. Smith’s impression of the destruction of the Japanese carrier Akagi: Douglas Dauntless dive-bombers turn away after releasing their bombs on to the carrier.

But the Japanese pilots pressed their attack regardless of losses. Remembering a Japanese with his aircraft on fire still holding steady to deliver his torpedo, Thach said: “As far as determination was concerned, you could hardly tell any difference between the Japanese pilots and the American pilots. Nothing would stop them...” Damaged by the dive-bombers and then crippled by air-launched torpedoes, the *Yorktown* was finally finished off by a torpedo from a Japanese submarine. The day ended with the destruction of the *Hiryu* by dive-bombers from the *Enterprise*.

The invasion of Midway was abandoned. The Japanese had lost four carriers and about 330 aircraft to America’s one carrier and roughly 150 aircraft. Japan had also lost a large proportion of its most experienced and skillful pilots. This was a crushing defeat and is rightly regarded as the turning point in the Pacific War.